GEORGETOWN UNIVERSITY

Echo Chambers After the Ban: Political Information on X in Brazil

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Motivation

Democratic governments often exert power over the governance of social media platforms. In recent years, these conflicts have sometimes escalated to full-scale block.

- Block of Russian website VKontakte in Ukraine;
- India and Nepal have blocked access to TikTok;
- US bill to sell TikTok;

Despite this increasing trend, we know little about the effects of these - often temporary - blocks on the information environment in democracies and how voters react to them:

- Information control in authoritarian contexts (Roberts, 2018; Boxell and Steinert-Threlkeld, 2022; Pan and Siegel, 2020; Lutscher, 2023)
- Golovchenko (2022): looks at the block of VKontakte in Ukraine in 2017, and finds no partisan effects on compliance with the block

Research Questions

- **RQ1:** How do partisan dynamics shape compliance with a state-imposed platform bans to social media platforms?
- **RQ2:** What are the consequences for information environments in a polarized democracy?

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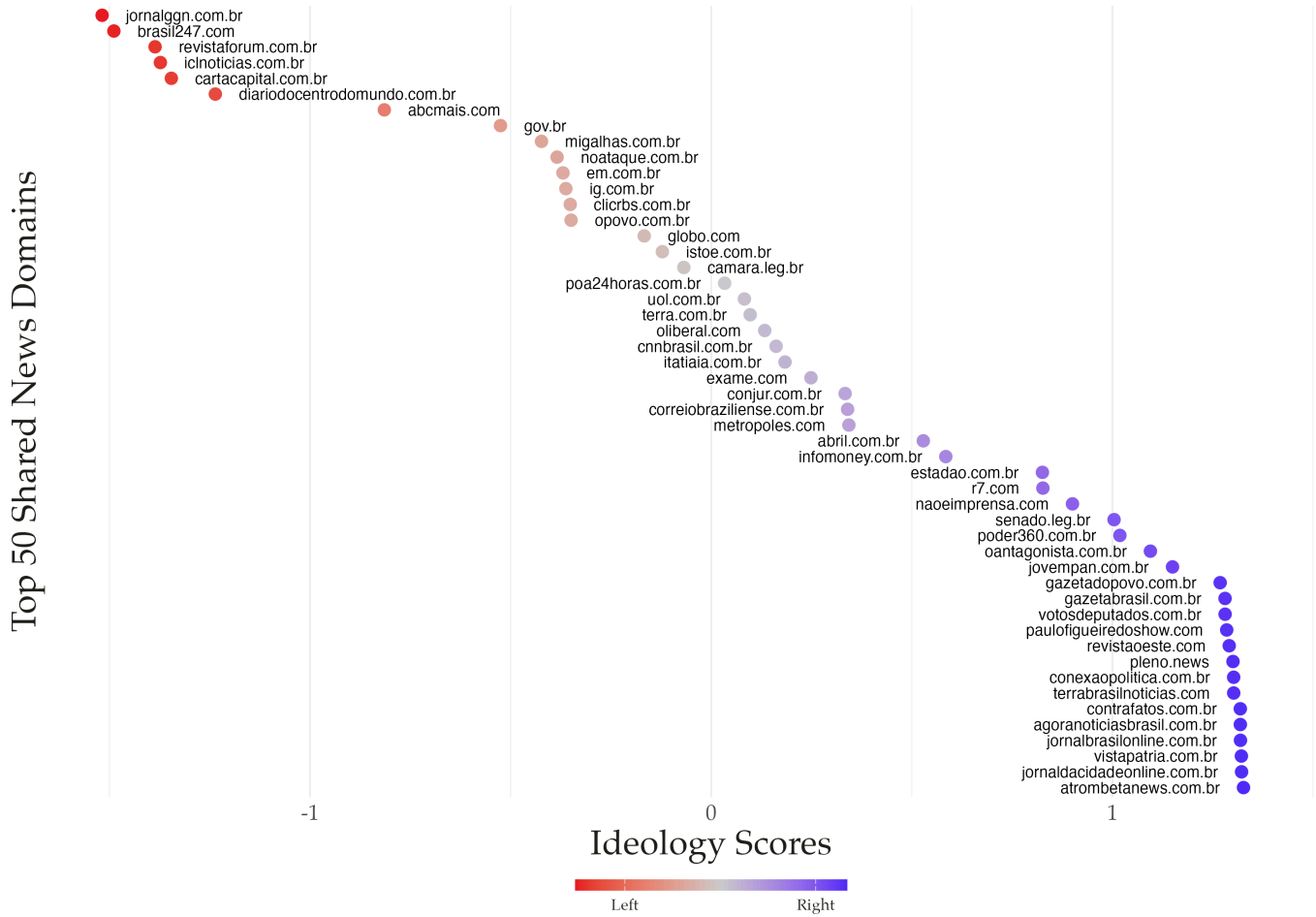
Carla Zambelli
@Zambelli2210
Dep. Federal (SP), eleita melhor Dep 2019 e
projetos, conservadora, mãe de João e esp
Translate bio
Writer
São Paulo, Brasil
carlaza
Joined March 2018
539 Following
2.5M Followers

Design and Methods

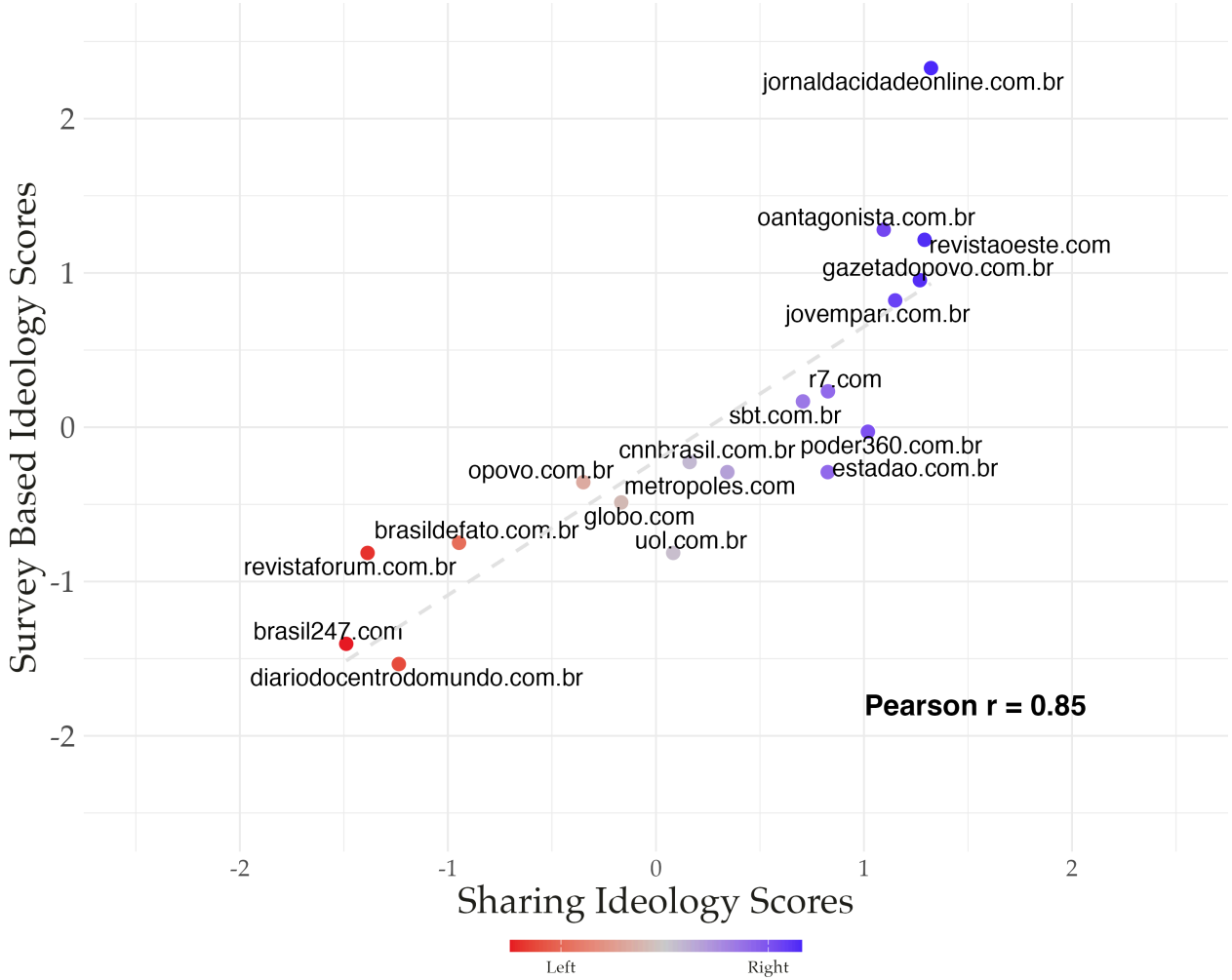
- **Use X/Twitter data from Brazil from months before and after the Ban**
- **Pre-Ban Sharing Data:** 90 days of data, starting before August 30, via the X Decahose API.
    - Use this data to estimate the ideology of media organizations and politically engaged users in Brazil
- **Ideology Estimation:** News sharing scores (Eady et. al 2024)
    - Columns: Political news organizations ~ 242 domains
    - Rows: Politically engaged users who share news often (>5 unique)~ 9061
- **Users Timeline:** Scrappe the timelines for these politically engaged users (~ 7,000 users)

Validation

Top-20 Domains: Ideology Score

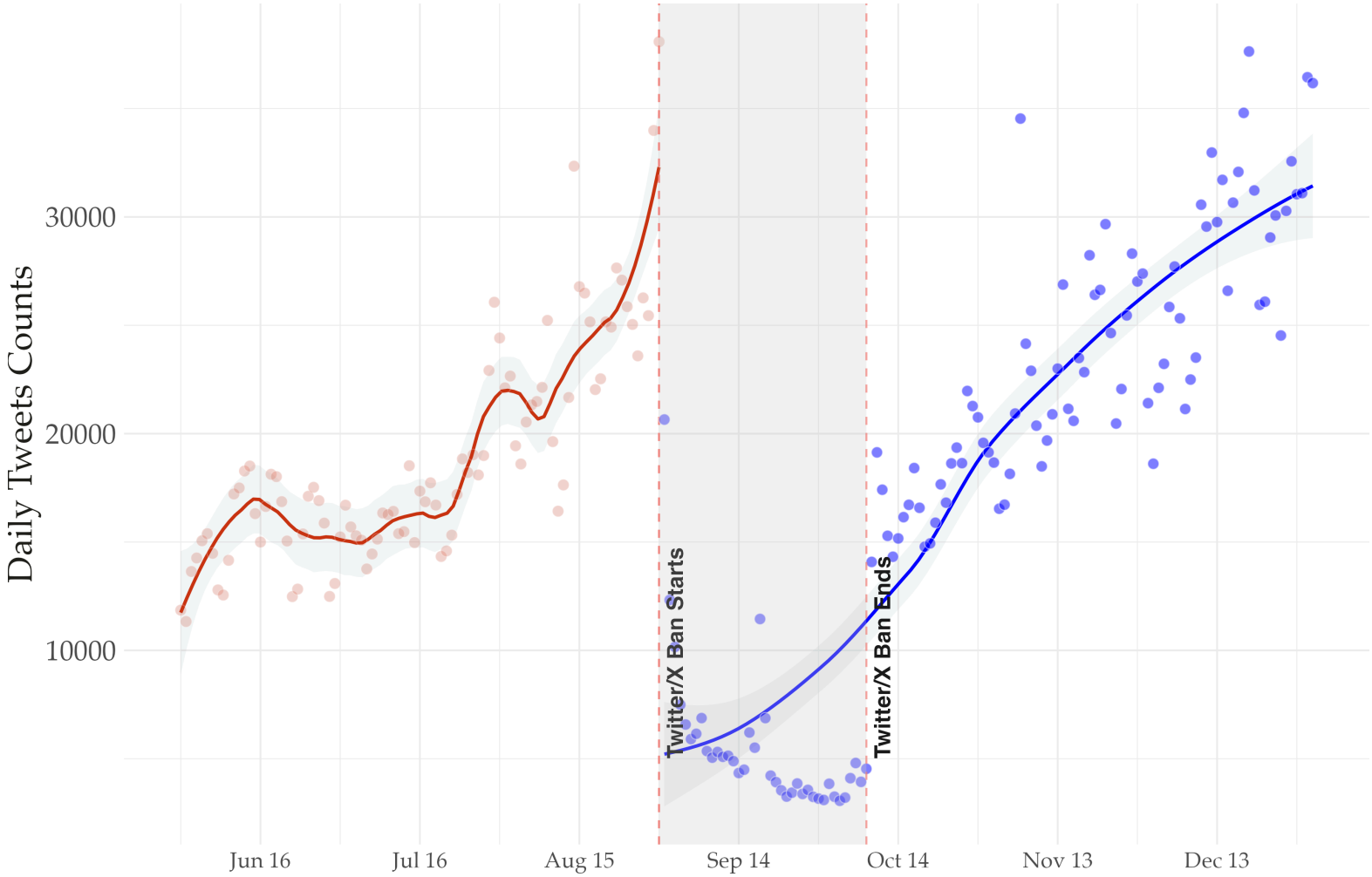


Validating with survey data

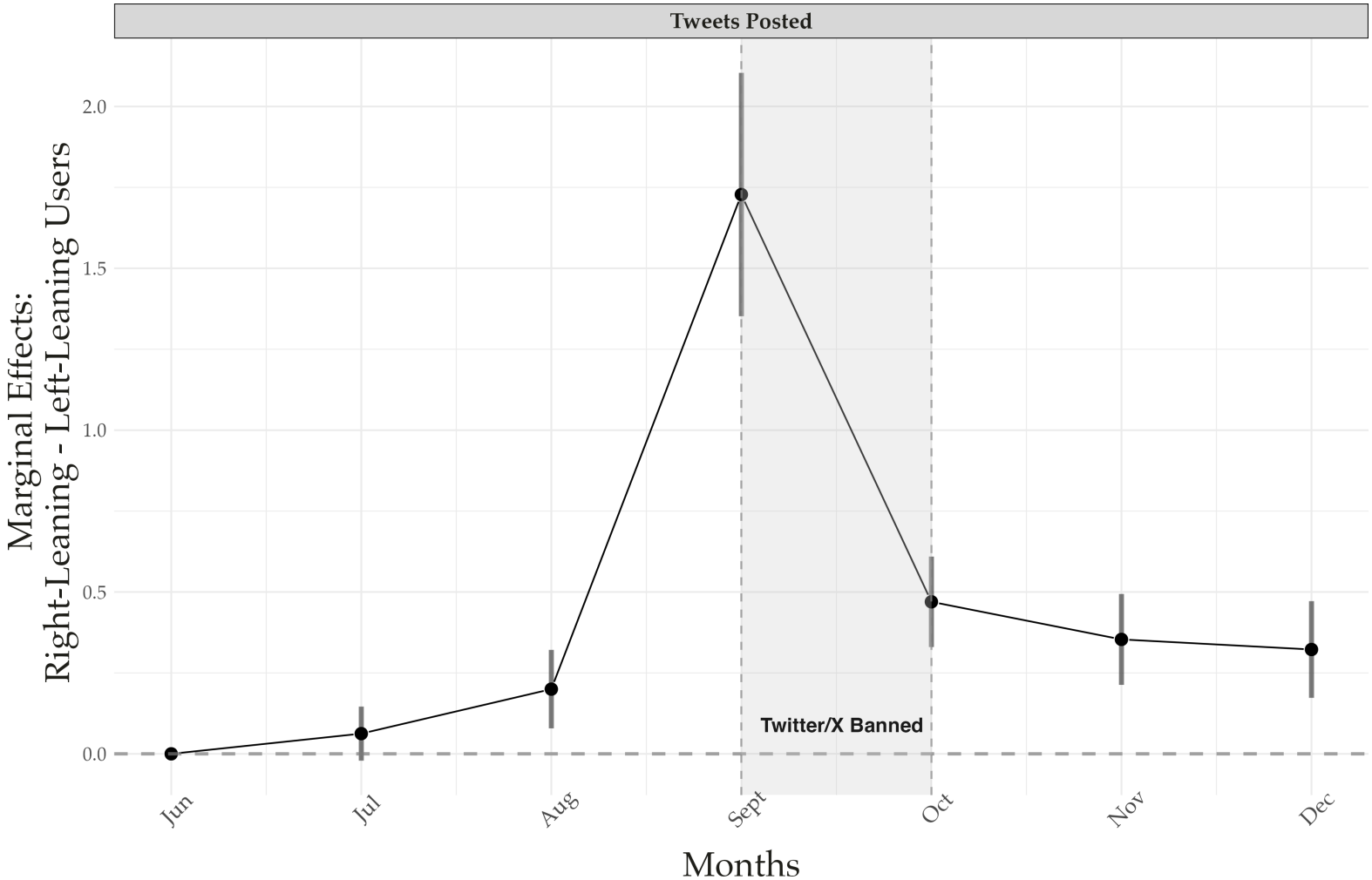


Results

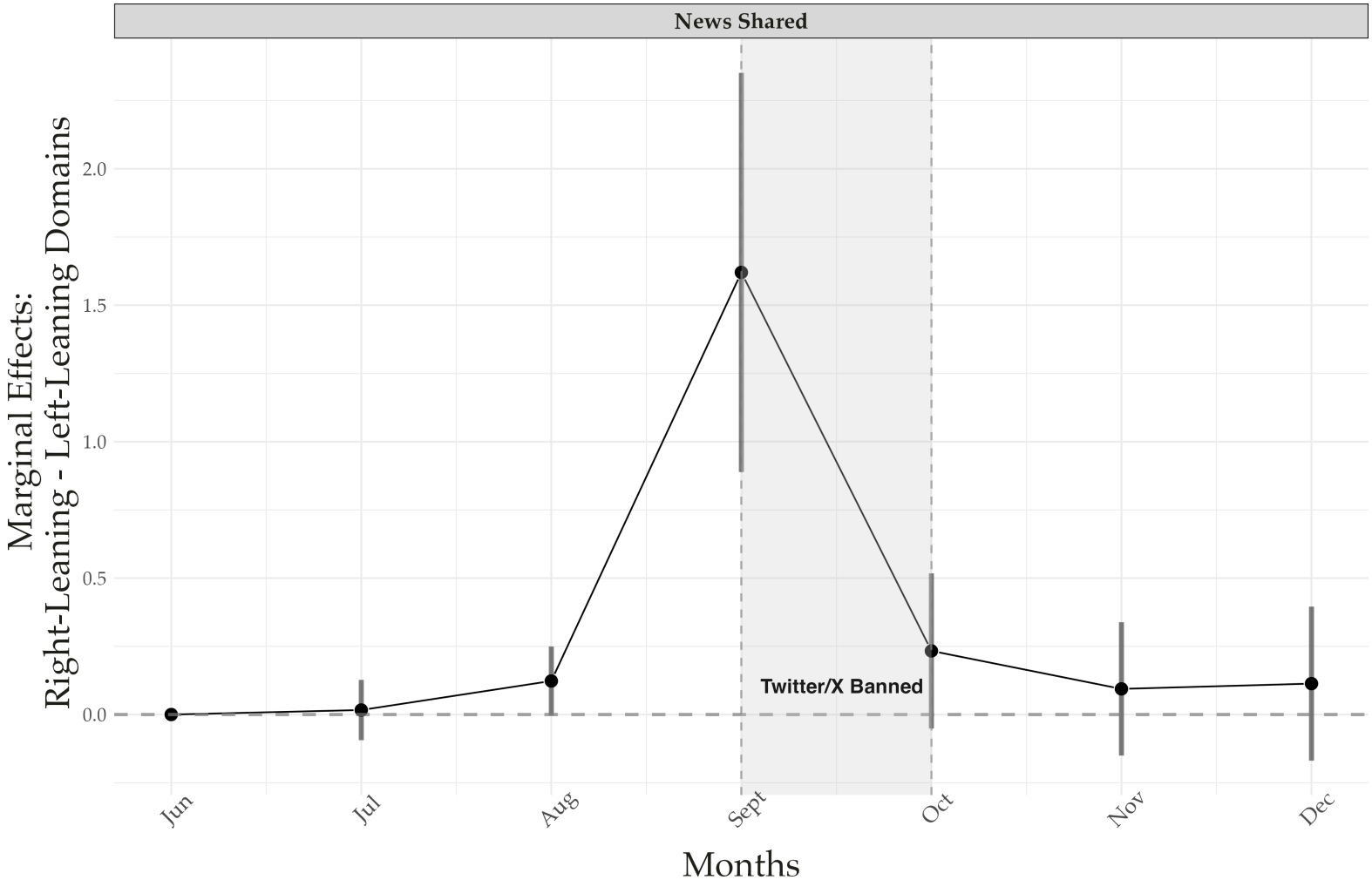
The Effects of the Ban on Posting Frequency



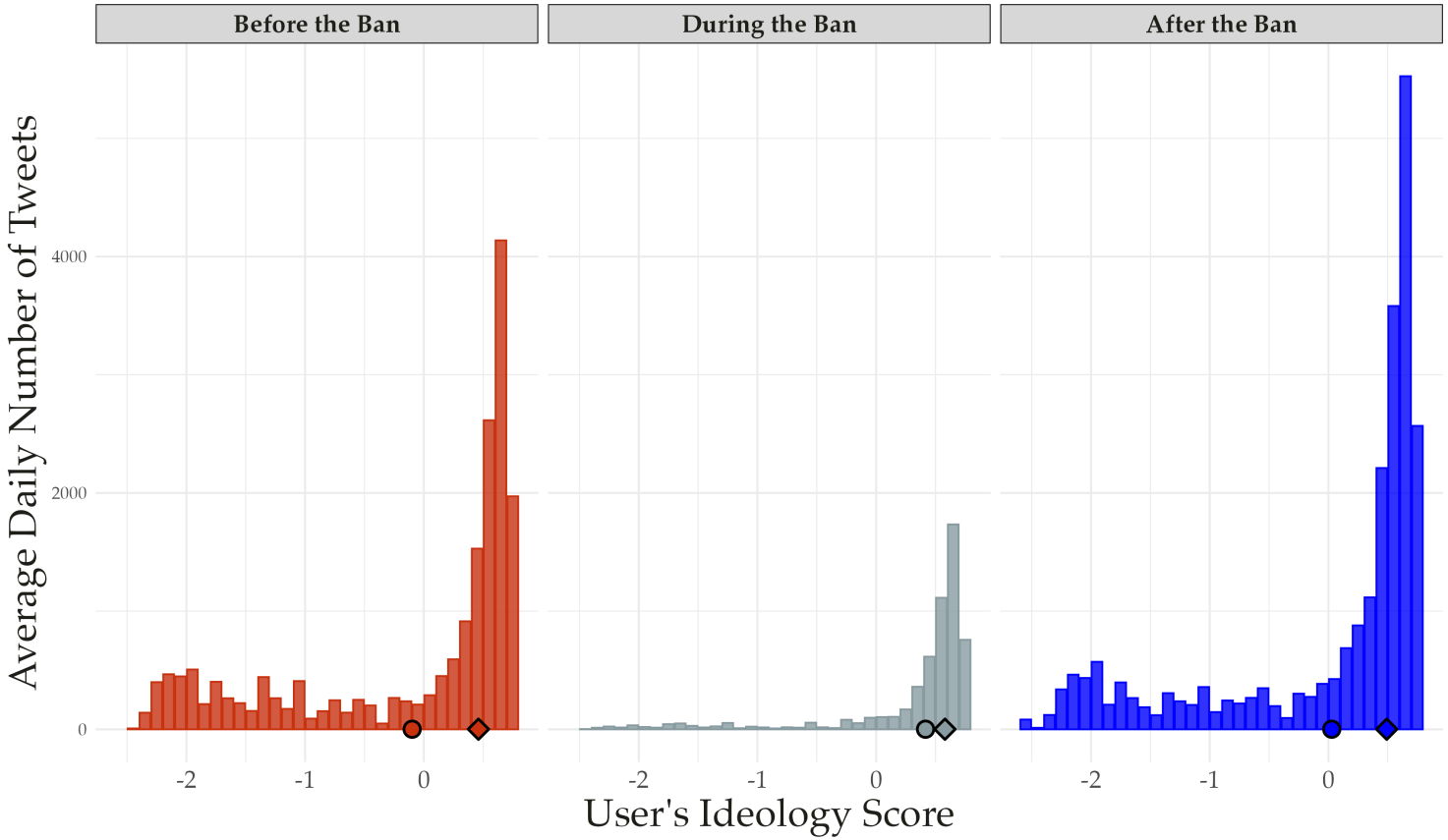
Event Study Estimates: User posts



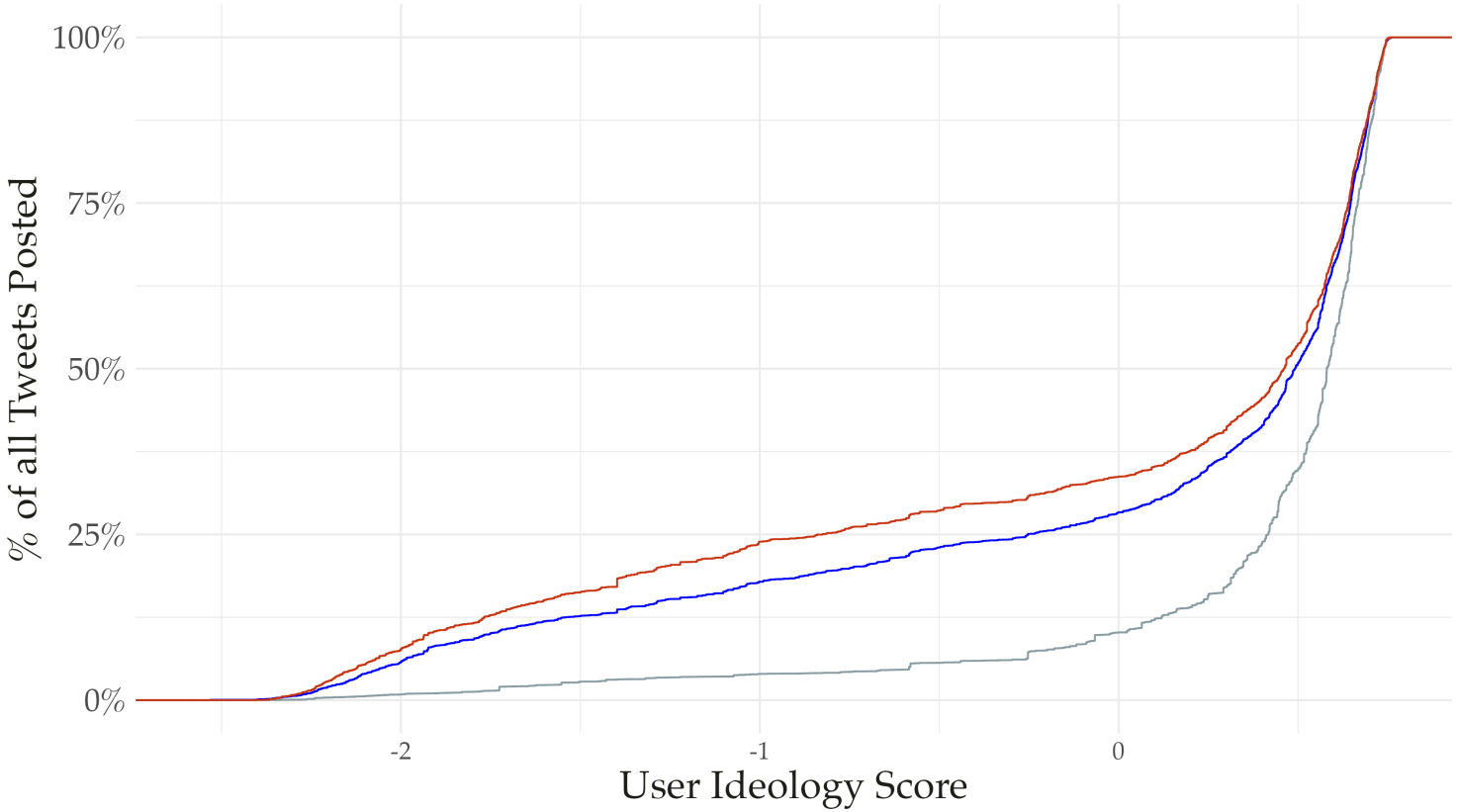
Event Study Estimates: News Sharing



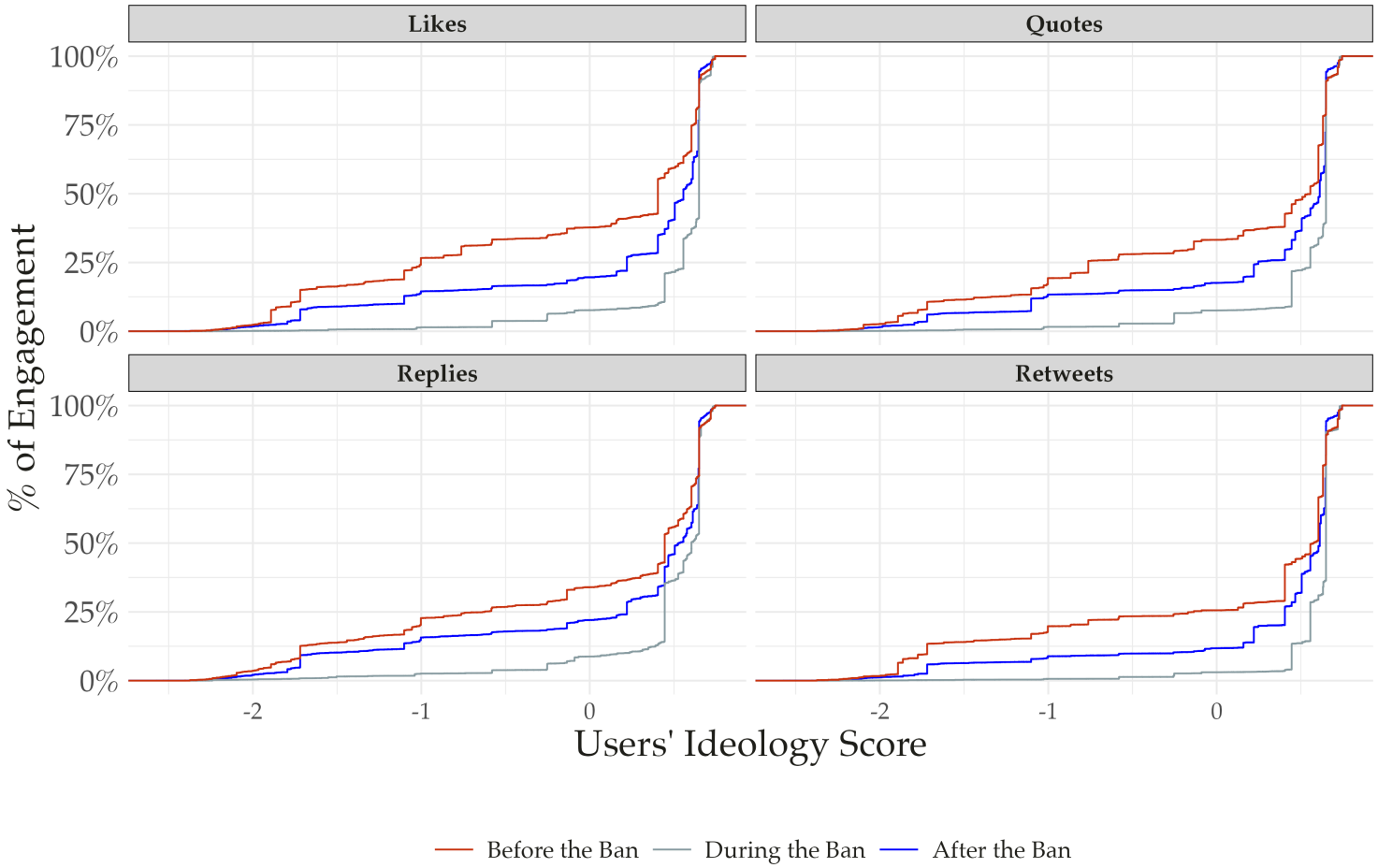
Tweets Posted Conditional on Users' Ideological Position



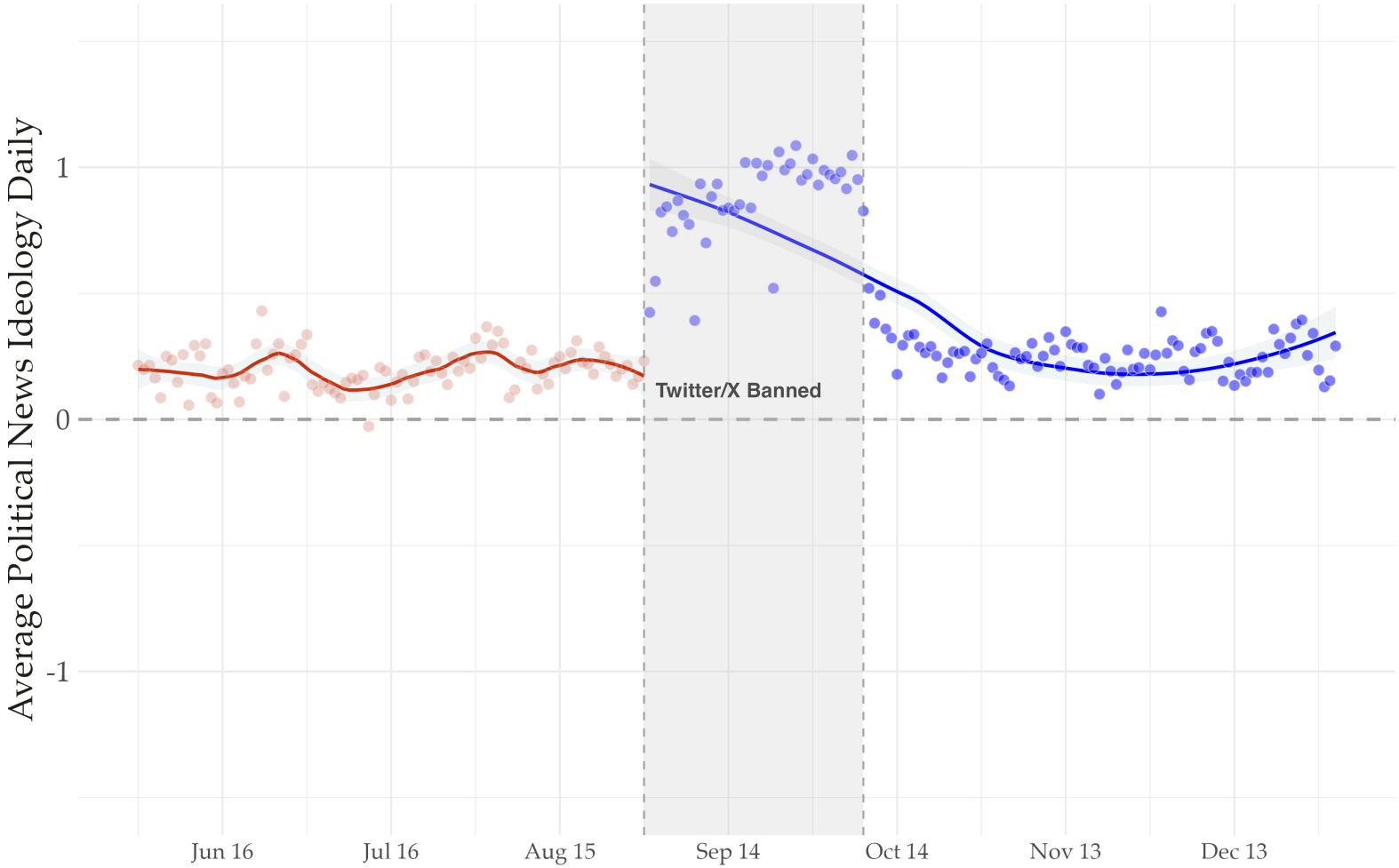
Concentration of Tweet Activity and News Sharing



Concentration of Tweet Engagement



Changes Informational Environment



High values indicate right leaning ideology

Conclusion

The ban substantially reduced use of the platform. **But** compliance with the ban was strongly driven by partisan dynamics

- Right-leaning users were the primary group to remain active
- After the ban:
  - the information environment on X was still more conservative,
  - right-leaning users more active,
  - tweeting more frequently, and receiving a higher share of the engagement
- Bans in polarized society can backfire, increase fragmentation and create platform echo-chambers
- Even short bans can have long-lasting effects on information environments.
- Future research: multi-platform effects, user migration, separate effects on political elites.

Thank you!